

2008-08-09 to 2008-08-10 - Rafting And Stretch Goals

Saturday morning found me waking up in a hotel in Denver and jumping into a vehicle and driving over two hours to do a half day white water rafting trip with some of my coworkers from Crown Partners.



It was my first time rafting and it was a lot of fun if a bit more sedate than I would have liked.

By the time we finished, returned the equipment, and drove back it was basically time to head to the airport. So I went to DIA still smelling of sweat and river water and caught my 9:37 pm flight.

I had hoped to sleep but the parents a few rows back who thought it was perfectly ok to let their kids run amuck on a late night flight decided otherwise. I was on the ground a little before 11 pm and didn't make it to bed until after midnight.

2:15 am came very early and I dragged myself out of bed and into my truck for the drive out to Baldy Village.

I'd sent out a general invite to most of the people I've hiked with asking if they were interested in a little 20 mile hike Sunday but strangely had almost no takers (just lots of 'sorry I'm busy' and a few 'you're crazy's) Even when I promised I'd be tired and jet lagged people decided they had better things to do...



...except for Tom. He actually had less sleep than me and still showed up. Though he only did the initial climb to Baldy with me then left it was nice to have someone along.



We were on the trail at 5 am taking advantage of an hour or two of darkness before the sun hit us and warmed things up.



The route is basically climbing right out of the gate and doesn't stop until you reach the peak 6,000 vertical feet later. Fun times.



Tom was under time pressure and made a beeline for the peak but I split off maybe a quarter of a mile before and ran up to the nearby summit called West Baldy. It's a sad little peak that doesn't make the HPS list probably due to its proximity to the "real" Baldy but a peak's a peak.



On Baldy itself I met a group which contained several friends from my WTC group. They were on a trip put together by one of the WTC leaders called Bunch on Baldy and had come up the Mahnker Flats trail. I tried to convince some of them to come with me but for some reason sitting on the mountain and eating apparently appealed more than sweating away for 6 more hours.

I did take great amusement in being recognized by one of their participants that I did not know as the "Scary Guy from Turtle Rock." (Turtle Rock is a local area where we do conditioning hikes every Tuesday and Thursday at 6:30 pm. We have a number of different groups that leave from the same parking lot broken out by difficulty and I run the hardest one called Strenuous. Some nights we have over 100 people at Turtle Rock and if I'm lucky I'll get 4 or 5 masochists willing to follow me up every hill I can find.)



After a quick summit photo Tom split off and headed down the mountain to try and make his softball game. I hefted my pack and set off for the remaining 2/3rds of my hike.



After dropping down the side of Mount Baldy I left the trail again and climbed a few hundred feet to the little bump named Harwood peak. Basically a rounded pile of shale with a GPS monitoring system set up on top. Unfortunately the summit register placed

up there by an HPS member has been destroyed, something that's been happening at a number of our peaks for the last year or two.



Dropping back down to the main trail I could see my next objective and rough half way point, the Baldy Notch. The Notch is the arrival point of the chair lift from the Baldy parking lot and has a restaurant that makes it a convenient refueling spot. It's the easiest way to climb Baldy since the taking the chair lift removes the need for a lot of climbing. As a result there were a number of people making their way up the trail and I chatted with several and even took one couples picture for them. One older guy was wearing a boy scout uniform was recovering from a recent injury with hopes of doing Whitney. We chatted for a few minutes while he rested and as it turned out later it was a good thing I talked to him.



Once again Devil's Backbone always makes for a good picture. I picked up speed a bit at this point and pushed on to the Notch.

Once I arrived I refilled my water bottles and took advantage of their facilities before setting out again. It was much warmer now due to the drop in elevation and the fact it was almost noon but I was carrying plenty of liquid and determined to make my last three peaks.



This part of the hike was also completely new to me as I'd never gone past the Notch before. The route was easy enough to follow even without my maps as there were signs periodically along the trail.

The Three Tee's refers to Thunder, Telegraph, and Timber, three peaks which occur along a trail running between the Notch and Icehouse Saddle. Icehouse Saddle is at the top of Icehouse Canyon and is a popular day hike known for being very pretty.



The first peak, Thunder, is at the top of another chair lift (this one doesn't run during the summer) and this time of year there's a clear road to follow. I ran into a few other hikers during the climb but all of them were heading back down after doing this one peak.



Telegraph had a decent climb to it as you switchback your way up the mountain. The descent down the other side was just frustrating as you look at switchback after switchback and think how easily it would be to do cross country to the next peak. Being out here solo (not to mention not wanting to stiff myself when it came to mileage) I stuck to the trail.



Baldy and West Baldy are the big peaks in the center of the picture. I'd come quite a ways by this time.

I'd also been hiking 10 or 11 hours by now and the lack of sleep/jetlag was really starting to hit me. I was moving pretty much constantly but from time to time I'd start as I thought I saw something out of the corner of my eye only to realize it was a stump.



Timber was the 6th and final peak of the day and noticeably easier than Telegraph.



Interestingly enough the register is a metal container embedded in a tree and it still bears the mountain's original name, Chapman. I have no clue why someone thought Timber was a more interesting name.



I startled some deer on my descent from Timber but they weren't really close enough for a descent picture.

I made it to Icehouse Saddle where a family was letting their teenage kids run around and hit each other with sticks. As much fun as that looked I headed down Icehouse Canyon.



Icehouse Canyon is known as a very pretty hike with many pools, springs, and small waterfalls but on this particular trip it seemed like it was never going to end.



I passed a bunch of folks on the trail but none were particularly chatty and I continued past pools...and cabins...and rocks...and more cabins...



Finally, at long last the canyon ended and I was looking at the parking lot. Success! Now I only needed to ask one of the many people getting ready to leave for a ride a few miles down the road to Baldy Village...

...Err, well, that's what I had been told anyway. Unfortunately when I got there I found there was only a single person getting into their car; a middle aged woman with 4 or 5 children running around who disappeared into the restroom and emerged wearing a dress that looked similar to some of those I've seen in pictures of fundamentalist Mormon communities. Based on the looks she was shooting in my direction I decided it was probably better not to approach her for a ride unless I wanted to be maced and or tasered.

I sat down on a rock and waited for someone else to emerge from the trailhead with no luck. After about 5 minutes I decided forget this, I'll start walking back and flag someone down along the way.

I then made two additional discoveries. 1) the road between the Icehouse parking lot and Baldy Village is rather longer than I remember (having only ever driven it.) And 2) I overestimated peoples willingness to stop for a rather smelly man in a bright orange hiking shirt staggering down the road.

I did however get honked at by a truck who apparently thought my walking along the side of the road was encroaching in his personal space to the point he needed to swerve into the opposing traffic lane and gun the engine.

At long last the Village was in sight when a truck passed me and hit the brakes. When I stumbled over to the window I saw it was the injured boy scout father I'd talked on his

way up to Baldy. He'd apparently recognized me and was nice enough to top and give me a lift the rest of the way. Granted, at that point it was only about 2 blocks to my truck but hey, it's the thought that counts.

Total mileage with the hike along the road came to about 20 miles and 8300+ ft of gain (the amount of gain my GPS recorded for the initial climb to Baldy was under what the map said it was.) All in all probably the hardest and longest hike I've done so far but I have a few rougher ones coming up in the next three months

-Matthew Hengst
2008-08-14